Well, we said, staring anxiously at our phones, it was going to happen eventually.

In fact, we'd had a heads-up that it was likely to happen that day. We'd been tipped, before heading off to the Halloween Apocalypse, that another apocalypse might be coming. More proof that the universe had a wicked sense of humor.

Meg, you ready for what's headed our way?

Kinda. Are you?

Yes.

We were sitting on her sofa, moments before I left for the airport.

Are you scared?

Yes. No. Maybe.

We're going to be hunted. No two ways about it.

I'll just treat it as if we're in the bush.

She reminded me of what I'd said in Botswana, when the lions were roaring.

Trust me. I'll keep you safe.

She'd believed me then, she said. She believed me now.

By the time I touched down at Heathrow, the story had…fizzled?

It was all unconfirmed, and there were no photos, so there was nothing to fuel it.

A moment's reprieve? Maybe, I thought, all will be well.

Nah. Calm before the shit storm.

19.

IN THOSE FIRST HOURS and days of November 2016 there was a new low every few minutes. I was shocked, and scolded myself for being shocked. And for being unprepared. I'd been braced for the usual madness, the standard libels, but I hadn't anticipated this level of unrestrained lying.

Above all, I hadn't been ready for the racism. Both the dog-whistle racism and the glaring, vulgar, in-your-face racism.